

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Saroj Mahapatra, PRADAN

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs and institution builders who have dedicated their lives to solving the country's most intractable problems.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we speak with Mr Saroj Mahapatra, Executive Director of PRADAN, one of India's most respected rural development organisations, started in 1983. Saroj is a leader who has spent nearly three decades working directly with the most marginalised communities in central and eastern India. Over four decades, PRADAN has grown into a strong organisation of university-educated professionals working across eight of India's poorest states, reaching nearly 3.4 million farmers and families. PRADAN pioneered the self-help group model in India in 1987, long before it became a mainstream national programme, and it has since shaped the design of flagship national schemes like MGNREGA and the National Rural Livelihoods Mission. Today, PRADAN's self-help groups generate millions in gross annual livelihood output for rural communities.

Neharika Vohra: Mr Mahapatra holds a Master of Engineering in Hydraulics and Irrigation from UCE Burla, and joined PRADAN as a young professional. He rose through roles in community mobilisation, state integration, and thematic leadership in climate-resilient infrastructure and natural resource management in Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh, before being appointed Executive Director in April 2022. He has worked with WFP, IFAD, UNICEF and the World Bank, and has been instrumental in building multi-stakeholder frameworks for rural development with both state and central governments.

Neharika Vohra: We are delighted to have Saroj with us today. Thank you — it's an honour to speak with you, Saroj.

Saroj Mahapatra: Thank you, Professor Neharika. I think this is a very good opportunity for an organisation like PRADAN to have an interaction with IIM Ahmedabad and ADCLOD, so I must thank you and the entire team at IIM Ahmedabad for this unique opportunity to share our experience and our learning with others. Thank you so much.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. IIM Ahmedabad is, in a way, quite indebted to PRADAN, because Vijay Mahajan and Deep Joshi, both IIM Ahmedabad graduates, were among the first to start it, right after their own graduation. So my first question to you, Saroj, is: could you give us a picture of what PRADAN looks like today — its scale, the states it operates in, the communities it serves, the range of its programmes, and the nature of your team and field professionals?

Saroj Mahapatra: PRADAN started in 1983 — it's a 43-year-old organisation now, and I'm glad to say we're working with more than 3.4 million households at present. Our major presence is in central India, in states like Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Odisha, West Bengal, and part of south Rajasthan — these are the states where we've worked very intensively for the last 35 to 40 years. More recently, we've started work in Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and part of Maharashtra, in the Vidarbha region. So at present we're working across 10 states, in 145 selected blocks and more than 40,000 villages. Our major focus is rural livelihoods — and livelihoods, to us, isn't only about income; it's about strengthening community institutions and enabling them to drive large-scale transformation in their own areas. That's one of our biggest strengths.

Saroj Mahapatra: We've recently completed our perspective-planning exercise, which we generally do for a period of five to seven years — this one runs to 2030. We're visualising a very ambitious goal: impacting the lives of 50 million people across close to 10 million rural households. There are four priority areas within that. The first is strengthening livelihoods — farm-based, non-farm-based, and the interdependencies between the two. The second is climate action: ecological restoration, and large-scale land- and water-based interventions. The third is gender equality — strengthening women's voice, agency, and collectives, which has been core to our work around self-help groups from the very beginning. And the fourth is nutrition and health, including WASH — water, sanitation and hygiene. These four priorities are also very much aligned with the national priorities as we see them.

Saroj Mahapatra: We're organised into what we call direct action teams — PRADAN professionals placed at the block and district level in our selected districts. There are, at present, 70 such teams across our 10 states, with close to 1,500 staff deployed, working directly with community collectives and with other ecosystem actors — government, civil society organisations, and donor agencies. Beyond that, we've placed close to 100 professionals within various government departments, at the district, state and national level, as part of formal partnerships. I'll go into more detail on that as we go, but that's roughly where we stand today.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. So PRADAN — even the name says it, Professional Assistance for Development Action — was founded on the distinctive idea that India's best-educated young professionals — engineers, managers, scientists — should choose

to work not in corporations, but alongside the rural poor. As someone who made that choice yourself, coming from hydraulic engineering and then joining PRADAN, what drew you to it? What was it about that founding conviction that felt so true to you?

Saroj Mahapatra: I joined PRADAN in 1996, just after my M.Tech in Hydraulics and Irrigation Engineering. At that time I had very limited knowledge of the development sector — to be honest, when I first went to the villages, in what was then undivided Bihar, and saw the level of poverty, I felt there were like-minded people within an organisation like PRADAN, and that together we could contribute a great deal to these marginalised rural communities. That was the basic, fundamental thought at the time.

Saroj Mahapatra: Over time, it became something more. I found real energy in working with the community and other stakeholders — we got recognition too, but honestly, the smiles on the faces of the rural poor have been one of the most motivating things for me. And the culture and climate within PRADAN itself mattered enormously — like-minded people, some from IIM, some from IIT, very highly educated people, working directly at the grassroots. That was a genuinely unique kind of organisation at the time; nothing else looked quite like it. Normally, people who graduate from reputed institutes move into managerial or supervisory roles — but here, high-quality human resources engage directly with the community, at the grassroots level, interfacing with people themselves. That's the core idea of PRADAN: giving back to society. Since I was fortunate enough to be educated, how could I give that knowledge back?

Saroj Mahapatra: Empathetic engagement is critical to that — if I can genuinely put myself in their shoes, I start to see how much stronger they actually are than us, given the vulnerabilities and challenges they live with, and the resilience that requires. That matters enormously. The other founding idea was that capable, caring people — Pradanites — can contribute far more than material resources alone. It's not that material resources don't matter, but if highly educated people can bring their head, their heart, and their hands together in harmony, nothing else compares. That's the core founding philosophy of PRADAN, and around it we built the idea of building people to build people — that was our mission statement in the early days.

Neharika Vohra: And what is it now?

Saroj Mahapatra: It's now about improving livelihoods — impacting the livelihoods of rural communities, enabling them. So we work with rural communities to enable them, and impacting their livelihoods is the means to that end.

Neharika Vohra: I see. You also mentioned in my introduction that PRADAN was a pioneer of self-help groups in India — a lot more has happened in the field since, but PRADAN started it, I believe in Alwar, Rajasthan, in 1987. What led to the creation of the self-help group model, and how has it grown since then?

Saroj Mahapatra: In 1987 — I hadn't joined PRADAN yet, but I know the history — we first started the self-help group model in Alwar district of Rajasthan, and, that same year, in Godda district of what was then Bihar, now Jharkhand. These groups were built around three basic principles. They were affinity groups, formed within a homogenous community, at the hamlet level. The first principle was mutual help — how members could support each other to build a cohesive group. The second was financial intermediation — because for small amounts, say five hundred or a thousand rupees, people were going to local moneylenders, since bank linkage wasn't yet systematised; that came later, after an RBI circular in 1992. So the idea was that self-help group members could save on a weekly basis, and that pooled money could rotate to meet individual members' credit needs — essentially doorstep credit. The third principle was empowerment — women's economic empowerment, livelihoods, market access, and so on.

Saroj Mahapatra: Over time, government took up this model. The special SGSY programme — Swarnajayanti Gram Swarozgar Yojana — came in 1998–99, and then, in 2010–11, the National Rural Livelihoods Mission. These built on the same basic principles, but at a much larger scale — universalising women's participation in self-help groups nationally. When we started, that scale component simply wasn't there; once the movement took off, it was. But those three founding principles — mutual help, financial intermediation, and empowerment — remain built into the programme, even as we work at a much larger scale now, and there's still a great deal of room to strengthen that sense of cohesion and affinity within groups.

Saroj Mahapatra: We've been involved with the National Rural Livelihoods Mission since its inception, across every vertical — gender integration, nutrition, inclusion of the most vulnerable households, livelihoods, universalisation, market linkage. Every vertical exists, but how they talk to each other is one level of challenge; and how these organisations become more gender-responsive and gender-transformative is another. I think those interventions are what's needed now.

Neharika Vohra: And that's possibly why, for the next several years, that's one of the areas you're focused on.

Saroj Mahapatra: Yes. We're involved with the National Rural Livelihoods Mission around livelihood resource organisations, with formal MoUs with the Ministry of Rural Development and at the state level too. Our people are embedded there, working with the system to bring our learning to a much larger scale.

Neharika Vohra: PRADAN's work spans a huge range — natural resource management, tasar silk, irrigation, MGNREGA, mobilisation, climate-resilient agriculture. What's been your logic for connecting these different threads at the village level?

Saroj Mahapatra: Our approach starts with social mobilisation — mobilising the community. Government does much of that now, but initially PRADAN did it, alongside a handful of other organisations like MYRADA and FES. Social mobilisation is the first step. The second is context-specific livelihood solutions — this isn't a copy-paste model. What works in Maharashtra can't simply be transplanted into Chhattisgarh, though the underlying principles and processes often can be. The third step is resource development — working with the community to understand what resources already exist and what's possible. We use quite a simple framework here, starting with the individual woman as a member of the household — because a woman's identity isn't reducible to the household alone — then the household, then the village, then the area, then the sector. Five levels in total.

Saroj Mahapatra: At each level, we look at the present situation, then define a desired end-state through a detailed, reasoned exercise with the community and other stakeholders. Say a farmer tells us they're only growing rice but want to reach 300% cropping intensity — that's the desired state. Then we identify the gaps: maybe there's no irrigation, no conservation structures, high surface runoff. Once we know the gaps, we can identify where to intervene. It's a very simple structure, but a powerful one — and it's now standardised enough that government functionaries and other civil society organisations use it too.

Saroj Mahapatra: The third component is production and productivity — in many of the places we work, productivity is roughly a third of the national average, so there's enormous room to improve it through better technology, better practices, and community resource persons. And the fourth is market linkage and entrepreneurship — connecting people to markets once production and productivity have stabilised.

Saroj Mahapatra: In the 1990s, our focus was purely thematic — irrigated agriculture, self-help groups, rainfed agriculture as separate strands. Over time we realised the area itself should be the unit of focus: you take up an area, understand its context, and derive contextual livelihood solutions from there. Tasar sericulture is a good example — in the forest-fringe areas of Santhal Pargana in Bihar, communities were already practising it, but with support from the Central Silk Board and the Ministry of Textiles, we introduced improved technologies, raised production and productivity, and now we're working across the entire value chain, end to end. That's why our livelihood portfolios have grown so large — but they stay closely tailored to context, to people's needs and priorities, and to what opportunities exist locally.

Neharika Vohra: That's really interesting — the methodology you've developed hasn't just evolved internally, it's become something of a standard for government and others in the development field. So your contribution isn't only to families at the village level, but to how development work itself gets done across the sector. The communities PRADAN serves are predominantly Adivasi, Dalit, among the most marginalised households in central and eastern India — some of the most complex development contexts in the country. What has this work taught you about poverty in these communities, and what does development actually require, beyond income and livelihoods?

Saroj Mahapatra: That's a very important question, Professor Neharika. Generally, when people talk about livelihoods, they talk about 'Lakhpati Didi' or income management alone. Income is necessary, but it isn't sufficient. When we talk about livelihoods, the basic notion has to be that it's driven from within the community itself — not top-down, but bottom-up. Community action and community stewardship are what drive any change, and what allow that change to be sustained.

Saroj Mahapatra: Being-level changes are especially critical. Twenty years ago, when I worked directly with communities in south Chhattisgarh or Jharkhand, people would say, 'I cannot do this.' Over time, through continuous engagement, through learning by doing, that shifts to 'Yes, I can do this.' That shift in mindset is one of the most critical things in livelihood promotion. Beyond asset creation, there are really three levels of change we look for. The first is being-level change — the most critical. The second is knowing-level change — bringing knowledge, expertise, technical understanding. And the third is doing-level change. All three are essential, both for undertaking any livelihood intervention and for sustaining it.

Saroj Mahapatra: The other part of this is what we call community taking charge — not cost to company, but community taking charge. In our grassroots methodology, we talk about the sense of agency of the collective — not the agency itself, which is hard to measure, but the sense of it. If people believe they're capable, they become capable. That shift in mindset is central.

Saroj Mahapatra: When we talk about livelihood promotion, we generally use what we call a 5A framework. The first A is access — to rights and entitlements: PDS, pensions, MGNREGA and now G-Ramji, all the entitlements available. The second is asset base — both of the individual household and of the village as a whole. The third is attitude — the individual's own attitude matters enormously. The fourth is ability — the being-level part: if she believes she's able to do something, she can do it. And the fifth is assurance — the sense that an organisation like PRADAN is there to absorb some of the early risk, so people can learn by doing. This 5A framework helps us understand how families are making decisions today, and what the change looks like across each of these dimensions over time.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. One of the reflections I had while you were speaking is how sad it is that a prolonged sense of lack — of anything — erodes a person's own sense of agency and ability, and how deliberately you work against that. We often talk about how privilege shapes us, but the lack of privilege shapes people just as powerfully, in different ways — that's something worth paying close attention to. PRADAN has often said its aim is eventually to withdraw — once a community is capable, PRADAN doesn't need to be there any more. Two questions on that: have you actually withdrawn from certain villages because they were ready? And given how many villages there are in India, will you ever really be able to withdraw completely, given that as soon as you finish in one place, another need emerges elsewhere?

Saroj Mahapatra: That's a very interesting question — funders often ask us something similar: what is your exit strategy? We generally call it a graduation roadmap instead, because no one really exits an area entirely. Think of a bank in a local area — nobody asks the bank to withdraw once it's established; it becomes a permanent part of that ecosystem, whether it's a Grameen bank, a nationalised bank, or otherwise.

Saroj Mahapatra: We started by working in 50 villages; today we're directly present in 10,500. The real question is one of intensity — if you only have around 1,500 people at the grassroots, can you really reach every individual household? You can't. So our unit of engagement is the collective — self-help groups, village organisations, cluster-level federations — rather than the individual household. And our own role within that keeps shifting. Early on, we used to run all the training ourselves — bookkeeping, accounts, technical skills. Now we build people who can deliver that training themselves, on our behalf or on behalf of other stakeholders. That engagement is continuously evolving.

Saroj Mahapatra: There are now many graduated collectives taking full charge of their own affairs. There are 92 farmer producer organisations — economic collectives of women — that are fully registered, independent entities, no longer dependent on PRADAN. Similarly, the broiler poultry cooperative NSPDT runs entirely on its own now; we provided handholding support for about seven or eight years, and it's now independent — in fact, it's the largest smallholder poultry business in India by volume, operating across Madhya Pradesh and Jharkhand. There are teams, like in Hazaribagh, where we've fully withdrawn because the community's cluster-level federations have been groomed to build their own linkages with government departments, plan their own livelihoods in detail, and implement those plans themselves. That's what graduation looks like in practice — it isn't a model that feeds continuous dependence.

Saroj Mahapatra: We also run internal longitudinal studies of households in villages where we've worked for 15 years or more, and some of our funding partners have supported us in certain geographies over that same period and recently commissioned an independent study through outside agencies. The results have been genuinely encouraging — they look at quality of life, including leisure time for women farmers, not just income; control over income; assets held in women's names. These are the kinds of indicators that study highlights.

Neharika Vohra: And are some of these studies publicly available?

Saroj Mahapatra: The donor-commissioned studies themselves aren't public, but our own website carries many quality-of-life and impact reports that are.

Neharika Vohra: I see — thank you. Now, coming to how PRADAN actually operates: the whole model depends on recruiting some of India's best-educated young professionals — engineers, MBAs, agronomists, people like you — and convincing them to spend their careers in remote tribal villages rather than in cities or corporations with all their glitz and glamour. How do you find these people? What does it take to hold onto them? And how do you reward them?

Saroj Mahapatra: The core offering of PRADAN really is the Pradanite. If you ask what PRADAN's core offering is, it's its people. PRADAN was founded on the idea that capable, caring people are essential to doing transformational work at the grassroots, and building people has always been one of our major areas of investment — whether inside PRADAN, or with communities, government, or civil society partners.

Saroj Mahapatra: We run a very structured programme called the Development Apprenticeship, lasting one year. We recruit from premier institutes — we used to go to the IIMs too, though less so now, largely because of salary expectations; today we mostly recruit from the NITs, IIFM, TISS, and various agricultural universities — essentially the best institutes we can reach every year. We have a strong recruitment process, with over 100 recruiters visiting campuses each season, and we recruit around 150 to 170 students annually — a fairly significant number by current standards. More than 4,000 people have gone through this Development Apprenticeship over the years, and roughly 90% of them remain in the development sector in some form. That, I think, is one of PRADAN's biggest contributions. Several organisations founded by former Pradanites are also doing very well — there are 21 such organisations. They're not part of PRADAN any more, but they carry the PRADAN idea forward, which is one of its real strengths.

Saroj Mahapatra: The Development Apprenticeship gives students a chance to explore both village life and themselves — many come from urban backgrounds with very little exposure to rural life, and once they see it from the community's own perspective, their whole way of thinking shifts, and they're able to contribute far more. After the year, they become full executives within PRADAN.

Saroj Mahapatra: Beyond that, we run a very detailed HR programme for every category of staff — we invest something like 15–20% of our time and resources into building people. It's a very human-centric, process-conscious, learning organisation — we learn as much from our failures as from our achievements. Every day at PRADAN is genuinely different, but everything, in some sense, is learning. The underlying belief is that professionals working with empathy can partner with communities and other stakeholders to transform lives and livelihoods.

Saroj Mahapatra: Empathetic engagement really is central to this. Over time, people learn how to facilitate a group meeting, how to run an achievement-motivation dialogue with a community — these are intensive trainings, things like the case-teaching method, achievement motivation training, group-process training, often designed with external faculty. We've had professors from IIM Ahmedabad and IRMA teach us about livelihoods, local-area economies, and circular economies, and we apply that learning directly at the community level, which sharpens it further.

Neharika Vohra: Of course. And would you say the youth's interest in coming to PRADAN has gone up or down in recent years?

Saroj Mahapatra: During Covid we faced real challenges — we recruited online, but the village-immersion and local-economy components suffered. But over the last four or five years, the trend has clearly turned upward — people are coming to PRADAN, and I've genuinely been surprised, because some of them were working at good software companies and are now choosing to explore rural work instead. Part of that is PRADAN's internal culture and climate; part of it is the freedom the work offers, and the work-life balance; and our compensation is now almost at par with the market, so there really shouldn't be any struggle for newcomers on that front.

Neharika Vohra: When you're hiring, do you weight empathy and understanding of community more heavily, or technical competence?

Saroj Mahapatra: There are really three things we look at when recruiting. The first is intellectual maturity, which typically comes through in the written test. The other two are social maturity and emotional maturity — how mature someone is in a social or group context, and emotionally. Empathy itself is something that can be developed over time — it's not that someone who isn't empathetic today can never become so. There's an important difference between empathy and sympathy: most people default to sympathy, not empathy. But with guided training — and the first year is a very intensive training period for our development apprentices — people develop that kind of affinity, that understanding of a community, by actually living within it.

Saroj Mahapatra: Whenever we work in a village, we need to understand its context and its people first, rather than imposing solutions from outside. That's the fundamental shift — very often, people offer solutions without properly understanding the problem. But if you understand the problem well, 70–80% of the solution is already there; people can largely work it out themselves. So we believe empathetic engagement can be built over time, but it requires real effort and application from the person themselves — only then does it actually develop.

Neharika Vohra: I'm curious how the curriculum for the one-year programme has evolved — it must have changed quite a bit over the years.

Saroj Mahapatra: When I joined, the curriculum was quite different — fundamentally it was about going to the villages and engaging very intensively with the community, but without much structure around it. Over time, we built a much more structured curriculum — gender perspectives were built in, with dedicated gender courses taught by our own faculty.

Saroj Mahapatra: The programme now begins with three months at the village level, understanding the rural context and village life, and exploring whether you're actually suited to this kind of work — while your friends in the corporate world are enjoying city life, can you enjoy rural life instead? That's the first phase. After three months, there's a structured 15-day classroom session covering the development perspective, an overview of PRADAN, and the development sector more broadly. The second phase is learning by doing — working directly with the community. Over roughly 11 months, we bring the whole cohort back together for what we call the Foundation Course — a central event for all the trainees, with a batch size of around 70 to 100 students. This programme started in the 1990s and we still run it every year; where our early batches had only about five people, our minimum batch size now is around a hundred.

Neharika Vohra: So you've been able to develop this curriculum and deliver it at scale.

Saroj Mahapatra: Yes — it's a genuinely unique programme, one that's contributed a great deal to the sector. Walk into almost any government department or funding agency today, and you'll find one or two Pradanites who've gone through it.

Neharika Vohra: Very good. I'm also curious — given how deeply your professionals engage with these problems on the ground, are you also feeding that knowledge back into academia? Very often our problems get framed through a Western lens, with one assumed way of solving them. Given the depth of PRADAN's grassroots work, are you feeding back into academic institutions, in terms of surfacing different ways of thinking about these problems?

Saroj Mahapatra: We've been in discussion with several institutions — IIT Delhi, for instance, has a Centre for Rural Development and Transformative Agriculture. When we spoke with them, they were very interested, and they ran a seven-day field-exposure visit to Jharkhand for their students. Similarly, students from TISS and other institutes come to us through internship programmes. But the point you're raising is a good one — we partner with universities largely for impact studies, but how we contribute to their actual curriculum is something we still need to think through properly.

Saroj Mahapatra: We did run a course with Ambedkar University, on development practice, with support from the Dorabji Tata Trust. And we're exploring a Rural Fellowship Programme now — we'd like to discuss the possibility with IIM Ahmedabad too, because a programme like that could genuinely help bring more high-quality students into the development sector, and orient them properly from early on.

Neharika Vohra: That's certainly one part of it — but I'm also thinking of things like how irrigation should be approached in a particular region, or what kind of cropping makes sense — a lot of that curriculum in universities is quite outdated, because it isn't grounded in real contextual knowledge. It would be genuinely useful if PRADAN could feed some of that back — but perhaps that's a conversation for another time.

Saroj Mahapatra: Definitely — that would be a great support to us.

Neharika Vohra: Let me ask about funding — what is PRADAN's funding model? Who funds it, and how?

Saroj Mahapatra: There are two types of funding. One is what we call the development support cost — essentially salary, travel, and administrative overheads. The other is programme cost — the actual cost of implementing something like a lift-irrigation scheme in a village. As a matter of principle, we take programme funding from government and route it directly to village organisations, self-help groups, or panchayats — not through PRADAN's own books — because it's public money, and our role is really about designing how to leverage flagship programmes like NRLM, or earlier MGNREGA and now G-Ramji, or PM-KSY.

Saroj Mahapatra: Our development support cost comes largely from CSR funding, which accounts for around 50–55% of PRADAN's central funding, along with philanthropic organisations like Tata Trusts and other Indian foundations, and some strong foreign contributors — the Gates Foundation, IKEA Foundation, Walmart Foundation — organisations whose thinking is well aligned with ours. Roughly 30% of our funding comes from foreign contributions, and the rest from government sources.

Neharika Vohra: And are there tensions or delicate balancing acts, given how many stakeholders and funders you're dealing with?

Saroj Mahapatra: That's a real, practical issue. But if you look at PRADAN's financial resilience, we deliberately keep some untied, unrestricted corpus funding that lets us experiment and build prototypes — some very good funding agencies support us on exactly that basis. We firmly believe projects are only a means to an end, never the end goal in themselves. I've seen many NGOs — and we partner with more than a hundred of them in various capacities — take up a project simply because funding becomes available, and hire people around that funding. PRADAN works the other way round: we recruit good people first, build good ideas, and the funding tends to follow.

Saroj Mahapatra: All our funding stays aligned with our own priority areas — if someone offered funding for urban work, for instance, we simply wouldn't take it, because our focus is fixed on rural livelihoods, collectives, gender, nutrition, and climate action. Around those priorities, we seek out funders who share our thinking. And I'm glad to say the number of funders in the rural-livelihoods space overall has grown. Looking at PRADAN's own numbers over the last three years, our financial growth has been around 17–20% a year — a substantial number — and our outreach and livelihood interventions have grown at a similar 20–25%. The two complement each other, rather than compete.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful — and that's clearly also a skill you build deliberately within your own team, helping funders complement rather than compete with one another.

Saroj Mahapatra: It is. It can be difficult to treat funders purely as partners, but if we can, it helps — because they, too, are genuinely interested in tangible, transformational outcomes at the grassroots. If we can influence them by showing real work around big ideas, funding generally isn't a problem. That's been my experience, and it's a strong conviction within PRADAN.

Neharika Vohra: Does PRADAN ever talk about wanting to be fully self-sustaining — working entirely without external funding? Or is that not even a relevant conversation?

Saroj Mahapatra: That's part of what I'd call financial resilience — a strong corpus lets you use the interest to help build the wider narrative. But I think of it in three parts: building the narrative, shaping the narrative — helping other stakeholders adopt it — and shifting the narrative altogether. PRADAN has built a great deal of experience across all three, and for that, we do need to keep investing in relationships with funding agencies and drawing support from various donors.

Saroj Mahapatra: CSR is a genuinely good space right now. Funders look for institutions with strong institutional capacity that can actually deliver — the ability to deliver, and credibility, matter enormously. I remember discussing this with one donor agency, who mentioned they'd funded 17 new NGOs the previous year. I said that sounded like very substantial growth for a single year, and they told me funding alone isn't the solution — it comes down to an NGO's institutional capacity to actually implement. But they said PRADAN's case is different: even with a 7–8% attrition rate at various levels, because we're constantly inducting new people who bring fresh perspective and energy, our overall delivery capacity never really drops, since we're recruiting continuously. That, from their perspective, was one of the biggest compliments PRADAN has received.

Neharika Vohra: As you said, one of PRADAN's real contributions is the Pradanite itself, which you've been producing consistently. In many conversations on this podcast, one recurring concern has been that a founder can become the bottleneck for an organisation, once their own vision and need for control gets in the way. PRADAN is a genuinely good counter-example — its founders are no longer in executive roles, and you, who joined much later, are now in the executive role yourself. Could you share a bit more about how that transition happened? How did it feel when the founders stepped back, and how has PRADAN managed to continue without a hitch?

Saroj Mahapatra: Vijay Mahajan left PRADAN around 1991–92 to start other organisations, and Deep Joshi retired in 2006–07. One of the genuinely good things about PRADAN is that it was never dependent on one person, unlike many smaller or mid-sized NGOs that stay very founder-centric. We have a highly decentralised leadership system — with 70 direct action teams, each one functioning almost like a smaller NGO in its own right, with its own non-negotiables around values, beliefs, practices and behaviours, held together by a strong internal governance system. We regularly review what we could have done differently, and whether, as we've grown, we're still holding to those non-negotiables. That internal governance, rather than external oversight, is what really matters for an organisation's long-term life.

Saroj Mahapatra: Once you give a younger person genuine responsibility — say, a team coordinator taking charge of an area — that person becomes accountable in a real sense. Making someone accountable without first giving them real responsibility simply doesn't work; responsibility, accountability, performance and learning all have to move together. We also have very good bench strength — more than 300 executives with over five years' experience working directly in rural communities, which is no small thing, and more than 50 professionals with over 25 years of experience within PRADAN. Fortunately, we've practised rotational leadership from early on — our management unit and Executive Director role rotate roughly every five years. I'm the ninth Executive Director of PRADAN; there were eight before me, and when I took over, the previous two Executive Directors were still working alongside me in their new roles. That's built a genuine culture of excellence, of participation, of leadership rotation, and of a non-threatening way of working through problems.

Saroj Mahapatra: If something fails, that's genuinely fine — we try to learn from failure rather than treat it as something threatening. We're bound by a strong shared culture around this: confrontation itself is treated as a kind of failure. When there's a difference of opinion within the leadership group, the question is how we surface it rather than let it sit beneath the surface, and then work jointly toward a solution. I think that's really the beauty of PRADAN — we often say PRADAN isn't really an organisation, it's an idea, and its institutional model is genuinely unusual. When I've discussed this rotational leadership approach with corporates or funding agencies, many of them simply don't believe it works — but it has, and we've stayed committed to it.

Neharika Vohra: That's a very interesting contribution too — showing how large, sustainable social-impact organisations can be led collectively, rather than through one person's singular vision or control.

Saroj Mahapatra: Exactly — collective decision-making, and collective management. There are various nodes in the structure — for instance, a state management committee responsible for all state-level partnerships and operations. But when you have a genuinely decentralised structure like this, integration has to be very strong. Our finance, accounts, HR — all our processes are decentralised, but tightly integrated at the centre through dedicated central functions: HR, a personnel unit, a monitoring-

evaluation-learning function, a development engagement support unit, a resource mobilisation unit. Each carries real responsibility, and while operations stay decentralised, they're bound together by clear rules and shared non-negotiables.

Neharika Vohra: I can see how some of that might trace back to Vijay Mahajan's own time at IIM Ahmedabad — Ravi Mathai, our first director, built some of those very structures here too, and they've endured. It's genuinely nice to see the same thinking carried into practice elsewhere. I have one more question for you, Saroj. In an organisation that's been around for 43 years, I'm sure there have been moments that didn't go the way you wanted. When that's happened, how has PRADAN found its way back?

Saroj Mahapatra: There's been something of a shift roughly every five to seven years. In the early years, from 1983 to '89, there were very few of us, so we worked alongside other organisations like ICAR. Then we decided to work directly ourselves, in Rajasthan, then Madurai, then Bihar, and focused on livelihoods. Our mission itself has changed over time — from 'building people to build people,' to 'impacting livelihoods to enable the rural community.' Roughly every five or six years, we renew ourselves to stay relevant to the present context — so it isn't that a 43-year-old philosophy has stayed frozen in place; the approach, the strategies, the way we work have all changed, even as the overall purpose has stayed the same.

Saroj Mahapatra: The organisation is very much mission-driven and purpose-driven, but flexible in its strategies. Over the last five or six years, for instance, partnerships with other civil-society organisations and with government have grown significantly. Early on, we believed we could largely do things ourselves, and we were one of the more significant players in the ecosystem — but over time we realised we're actually a fairly small player on a very large canvas, and that multi-stakeholder partnerships are essential for large-scale transformation. So we now work closely with government departments on their own flagship programmes, engaging with and influencing the system from within, while also working with smaller civil-society organisations to strengthen their own systems and processes, so they too can access better funding and support. That's been one of the more significant shifts in our engagement over the last seven or eight years.

Saroj Mahapatra: One challenge that comes with growth is the sheer weight of expectation from other states — we recently started operations in the Vidarbha region of Maharashtra, and almost immediately began getting requests from Tripura, Meghalaya, Assam, and Uttar Pradesh, asking us to come and start work there too. It isn't easy — there's a lot of external demand, but we're clear that our model can't be a light-touch one; it needs to be a genuinely intensive, 15-to-20-year commitment before real change becomes visible. That's why our perspective plan explicitly demarcates the geographies we're targeting, and we expand only as real opportunities align with that.

Saroj Mahapatra: The second challenge is how scale itself gets defined — people usually think of scale purely in terms of numbers, the size of your impact. But we think of scale differently: as also the depth of intervention. If a household moves from two livelihood activities to five or six, and from earning one lakh rupees to five lakh rupees, that's scale too. So there's horizontal expansion, and there's depth of intervention — and both matter.

Neharika Vohra: Earlier you said PRADAN is a learning organisation — and everything you've just described really shows how you've kept reinventing yourselves and kept learning as you've gone. That's a great lesson for all of us in building organisations like that. Thank you for sharing so much detail. My last question is about the young people who might be listening to this — people with good degrees, thinking about working in the rural sector. What advice or thoughts would you share with them, to help them make that choice?

Saroj Mahapatra: I have two or three suggestions. First, I'd encourage young people to come and explore the rural areas themselves, and find their own sense of meaning in what they might contribute. People from institutions like IIM can genuinely add a great deal to this space — transforming lives and livelihoods. And livelihoods, again, isn't only about income; it's about the whole landscape — how the ecosystem is changing, how community-centred, decentralised action can be leveraged, how flagship programmes can be used well, and what outcomes look like at the level of people, systems, and organisations, approached with a systems perspective rather than one-on-one. I think there's real scope for young professionals to come and work with organisations like PRADAN, or others, to explore rural development more broadly — because if we're serious about Viksit Bharat 2047, we also need a Viksit Village, a Viksit Panchayat, Viksit collectives; that mission only gets fulfilled once our collectives are genuinely strong, and there's already a great deal of evidence pointing toward what that looks like.

Saroj Mahapatra: Second — and this comes up often, both from outsiders and within the sector itself — people ask a great deal about monitoring systems and evaluation systems, about how we stay relevant. But I think the real focus should be on learning. Instead of an 'MEL' system, we call it 'LME' — because in the usual ordering, monitoring comes first, and monitoring and evaluation end up as the primary focus, with learning treated as secondary. In an LME system, learning is the primary focus, and measurement, evaluation and accountability follow from it. If young professionals can approach this work through a lens of learning — genuinely open-ended exploration, alongside a real contribution to the rural community's own journey — I think that's what I'd hope for from them.

Saroj Mahapatra: Not everyone will end up in the rural development sector, of course. But wherever they go, I think these broader principles hold — if they can spend even two years working in rural areas, in a good organisation, that learning stays with them in whatever they do afterward, whether in government, the public sector, or academia — including, as you rightly pointed out, in how our course curricula themselves get shaped. All of that, I think, brings more quality, more rigour, and more excellence to everyone involved.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much for your time, and for such detailed answers, for our audience and for me personally — I learned a great deal, and I hope others listening have too. We wish you all the best in continuing this wonderful work. Thank you.

Saroj Mahapatra: Thank you so much. Thank you so much.